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Newsom convenes legislators to fund deportation defense, lawsuits against Trump admin

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(The Center Square) - As the most expensive wildfires in U.S. history rage across Southern California, Gov. Gavin Newsom is convening a special session of the legislature to "Trump-proof" the state by providing funding for the deportation defenses of illegal immigrants, and funding state and local lawsuits against the federal government.

In their opposition to funding deportation defenses for illegal immigrants, Republican leaders noted such funding would be used to prevent the deportation of individuals such as the illegal alien from Mexico who was caught with a bicycle and a blowtorch near the massive Kenneth fire while out on probation.

The proposed bills would provide $25 million for state and local lawsuits against the administration of President-elect Donald Trump, and an additional $25 million largely for deportation defenses.

"The new Administration has already promised to launch an all out assault against LGBTQ people and attempt to deport our immigrant neighbors, who even now are helping to contain the LA wildfires and mitigate the property damage," state Sen. Scott Wiener, who authored the special session's Senate bill, said in a statement. "Senate Democrats are particularly proud to provide funding for providers of legal aid services, which know our communities' needs best and are best positioned to defend at scale the millions of individuals and families that will be impacted by the incoming Administration's extreme agenda."

As reported by Fox News, a foreign national from Mexico named Juan Manuel Sierra-Levya was captured by citizens and placed into police custody after being caught near the Kenneth Fire with a blowtorch. Due to sanctuary state laws that limit cooperation with federal immigration authorities, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement may not have its detainer request with the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department honored.

"Gavin Newsom's deal with legislative Democrats will funnel $25 million to left-wing groups to fight against deporting people like this," said California Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher, R-Yuba City, on X. "Regardless of whether he started the fire, he is a repeat criminal here illegally and should be removed from the country."

California faces annual budget deficits of $20 billion or more starting in 2026.

While a hearing was scheduled for the special session on Tuesday morning, KCRA reports the hearing has since been postponed until further notice, as the district of Assembly Budget Committee Chairman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, is under evacuation orders and threatened by the Palisades and Kenneth fires. Democrats aim to pass the bills by Trump's inauguration on Jan. 20.

With the state insurer of last resort lacking funds to cover fire losses that could add up to hundreds of billions of dollars in direct and indirect losses, the three options are to pass major assessments to all customers, or get a state or federal bailout. While a major assessment – possibly in the tens of thousands of dollars – may not get approved by state regulators, the state has "no capacity for new commitments," and faces rising deficits, meaning a bailout is likely to have to come from the now Republican-controlled federal government.

This means Newsom may soon have to choose between passing on significant costs to Californians, whether through higher taxes or approving major insurance assessments, or getting a federal bailout but giving up on some of his key priorities.

"Yesterday I met with President Trump. I am convinced we have an opportunity to bring sanity back to California

and render Newsom irrelevant," said Congressman Kevin Kiley, R-California, on X. "The President understands how insane water and fire policies helped create the nightmare in LA. In these and many other areas – the sanctuary state, electric mandates, high-speed rail, health care for illegal immigrants, homelessness, crime – we can fight for the people of California by fighting against their corrupt and incompetent governor."

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